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Sports and Identity Analysis

Part 1: Research Intersection

My topic is how football broadcasters describe Black and white players using totally different language, even when they're doing the exact same thing on the field. This is interesting to me because I've watched football my whole life and never really clocked it until I started looking, and now I literally can't unhear it. Every broadcast has some announcer calling a Black quarterback "explosive" or a "freak athlete" while the white quarterback two plays later gets called "cerebral" or a "student of the game." It's crazy because nobody's trying to be racist, it's just baked into the way the game gets talked about, which honestly makes it more interesting than if it was just some guy being obviously biased.

Part 2: Popular Press Research

There's actually a good amount of mainstream reporting on this, and once you start looking you realize it's not some fringe internet theory, real journalists have been writing about it for years. An NPR piece with University of Colorado professor Pat Ferrucci lays out the basic pattern pretty clearly: white athletes get described in terms of intelligence, effort, and leadership, while Black athletes get described in terms of physical strength and natural ability, and Ferrucci points out that none of the individual words are insulting, it's the fact that they cluster by race that's the problem (NPR, 2019). A WBUR "Only A Game" story on the same topic goes even deeper into why this matters outside of sports, interviewing journalist Derrick Z. Jackson, who makes the point that if broadcasters keep treating white players as the "smart" ones, that affects who gets hired into coaching and front office jobs after their playing days are over, since those jobs go to whoever's seen as the cerebral guy (WBUR, 2020). The third piece, from Andscape (ESPN's site that covers race and sports), covers a study where computer scientists ran millions

of words of broadcast transcripts through AI and found the exact same pattern researchers have been reporting by hand for decades, white QBs get first-named less and get "leader" type words, nonwhite players get words like "speed," "gifted," and "beast" (Andscape, 2020). What's cool is these three articles all land on the same conclusion from totally different angles, a professor, a journalist doing interviews, and literal AI analysis of broadcast data, so it's not just one person's opinion.

References

- Andscape. (2020, January 8). *Can artificial intelligence help us understand racial bias in sports?*
- NPR. (2019, March 29). *Pat Ferrucci: How does the language of sports journalism reveal racial biases?* [Radio broadcast transcript].
- WBUR. (2020, June 26). *'Crafty' vs. 'sneaky': How racial bias in sports broadcasting hurts everyone.* Only A Game.

Part 3: Visual Media

For visual media I watched ESPN's *Year of the Black Quarterback* special, which is part of their Undefeated/Andscape series that's been running for a few years now during Black History Month. The special runs through the history of Black quarterbacks basically getting locked out of the position for decades, going all the way back to guys like Marlin Briscoe, up through current guys like Patrick Mahomes and Lamar Jackson, and one part that stuck with me was Hall of Famer Warren Moon talking about how the "thinking" positions like quarterback, center, and linebacker were the ones Black players "weren't allowed to play" earlier in his career. Its interesting watching it right after reading all the broadcaster language stuff, because the special basically shows you the historical version of the exact bias the articles are describing today, like the stereotype about who's "smart enough" to play QB isn't new, it's literally decades old and just shows up differently now in commentary instead of outright roster bans.

Reference

- ESPN. (2020). *Year of the Black quarterback* [Television special]. The Undefeated/ESPN.

Part 4: Academic Research

There's actually a solid amount of peer reviewed research backing up what the popular press is saying, going back further than I expected. The biggest one is a 2019 computational linguistics study by Merullo and colleagues, who built a dataset of over 1,400 football broadcasts spanning six decades and used NLP models to analyze how announcers talked about players, and even after controlling for stuff like position and game situation, they still found commentators disproportionately attributed intelligence and leadership to white players and athleticism to nonwhite players (Merullo et al., 2019). This one's cool because its not relying on people's gut feelings about bias, its literally running the numbers on a quarter million player mentions. A second study, this one out of the Netherlands, interviewed actual sports media professionals about their own reporting, and found something kind of depressing, most of the journalists acknowledged racial stereotypes exist in sports commentary in general but almost none of them thought they personally did it, which the researchers point out is a pretty big blind spot for people whose entire job is picking the words to describe players (Van Sterkenburg et al., 2021). A third study looked at this from the audience side instead of the broadcaster side, watching English football fans consume game coverage in real time and finding that white fans reproduce a lot of the same racialized "shades of whiteness" framing that they're hearing from commentators (Van Sterkenburg & Walder, 2024). Put together these three kind of surround the whole system, how commentators actually talk, whether they know they're doing it, and how it lands with the people watching at home.

References

- Merullo, J., Yeh, L., Handler, A., Grissom, A., II, O'Connor, B., & Iyyer, M. (2019). Investigating sports commentator bias within a large corpus of American football broadcasts. EMNLP-IJCNLP.
- Van Sterkenburg, J., de Heer, M., & Mashigo, P. (2021). Sports media professionals reflect on racial stereotypes and ethnic diversity in the organization. *Corporate Communications: An International Journal*, 26(5), 31-46.

Van Sterkenburg, J., & Walder, M. (2024). Race and whiteness in football talk amongst English fans. *Soccer & Society*, 25(4-6), 397-410.

Part 5: Personal Conversations

I shared the Andscape article and the NPR piece with three people and hopped on calls with all of them. My roommate Tyler, who played wide receiver in high school, said the pattern tracked with his own experience getting recruited, he remembers coaches talking about "explosiveness" and "burst" for him but using words like "IQ" for a white QB on his team who honestly wasn't even that good, and he asked whether this shows up differently at the QB position specifically versus other positions, which I didn't totally have an answer for. My aunt, who's a middle school teacher, brought up a really good point I hadn't thought about, which is that this same "smart vs. athletic" language shows up in how teachers talk about students too, so she thinks the sports broadcasting version might just be one visible example of a much bigger societal pattern instead of something unique to football. The third person I talked to was my friend's mom, who coaches club volleyball and is one of the only women coaching at that level in our area, and she pushed back a little, saying that in her experience the "brains vs brawn" framing gets talked about a ton for men's sports but almost nobody studies whether the same pattern shows up in women's sports commentary, which honestly seems like a solid direction for more research since basically all the studies I found were about men's football. All three conversations left me thinking this topic is way bigger than just football broadcasts.

- Tyler, roommate, former high school wide receiver
- My aunt, middle school teacher
- Friend's mom, club volleyball coach, one of few women coaching at that level locally

Part 6: Summary

My topic is the way football broadcasters describe Black and white players using different language, even when the players are doing the same things on the field, with white players more often getting "smart" and "leader" type words and Black players more often getting "athletic" and "natural talent" type words. This matters because language shapes perception, and

if broadcasters keep associating leadership and intelligence with one race, that effects real decisions down the line, like who gets hired into coaching and front office jobs after their careers end. What makes it interesting is that this isn't some outlier announcer being obviously racist, its a pattern that shows up across decades of broadcasts, gets confirmed by AI analysis of literally millions of words, and even the broadcasters and fans themselves mostly aren't aware they're doing it. The effects go beyond sports too, since a couple people I talked to pointed out the same "smart vs. athletic" framing shows up in classrooms and other parts of life, which means football broadcasts might just be the most visible, most studied version of a much bigger pattern in how our society assigns intelligence and physicality based on race.